



Blending Well

Get to grips with Blender's unique user interface

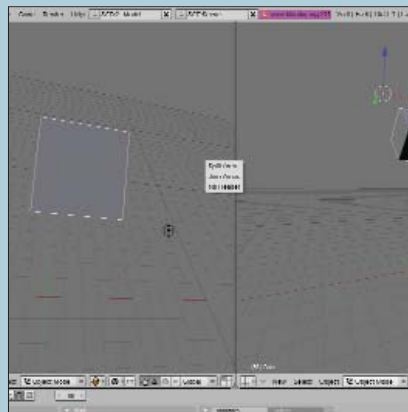
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Blender is a very powerful open source tool for creating, modelling, and rendering 3D scenes. If, however, you're used to a different tool, or if you're just starting out, you might find yourself a little taken aback by the interface. However daunting it may seem, Blender's interface is actually quite easy to get used to—you just need to clear your head of all those “traditional” interfaces.

The Interface

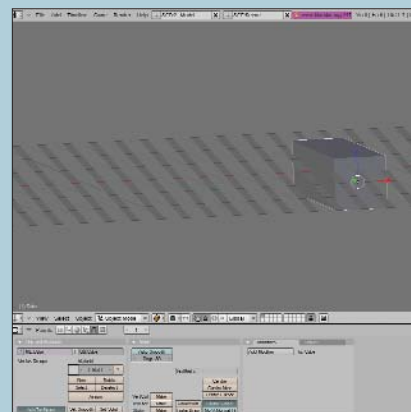
When you start up Blender, you'll be faced with its default interface (or screen, as it's called). At the top, you'll see the familiar menu bar that lets you open and save files, render your scene, or get help. Next to your main menu is a drop-down that lets you select the screens you want to work with. The default is Model (where you model your 3D objects), and you can choose from Animation, Material (where you apply materials to your objects), Sequence (advanced animation), and Scripting. You don't really *need* these screens—they're just organised differently to speed up your work.

Below this menu bar is the 3D window, where you'll be setting up



Split the 3D window to see your work from different angles

your scene. At the bottom of this window is the window header that lets you specify what type of window this is (like a script editor or file browser), or in the 3D view, which angle you're viewing your scene from. To work better, you'll need more than one of these windows—3dsmax's extremely useful four-pane layout comes to mind—and you can do this by moving the mouse to the edge of the window, right-clicking and selecting Split Area. Doing this at the top or bottom edge splits the window vertically, and at the sides splits the window horizontally.



The difference between an engineering drawing and reality lies in the perspective

Finally, the bottom of your screen is occupied by the buttons window, which is further divided into panel groups, which in turn contain panels where you can edit a whole host of parameters for your objects (whew!).

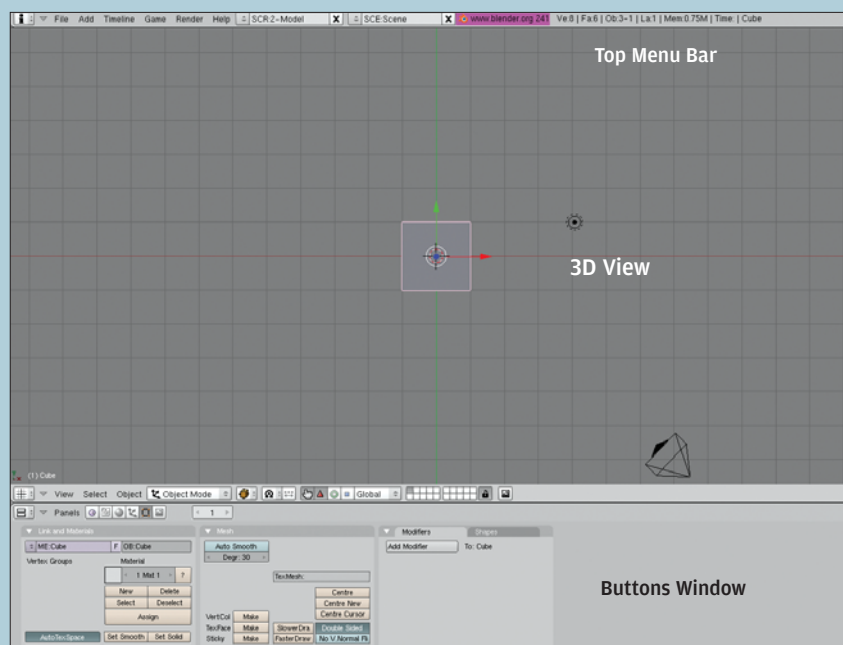
Now that we've taken a quick tour of the interface, let's see what can be done about...

Getting Around

Before moving any further, we should mention that using Blender will require extensive use of the mouse as well as the keyboard, so if you're not seated gamer-style, you should be.

By default, you're viewing the scene from the top. To fly around the scene (the term is *orbit*), hold down the middle mouse button and drag. You'll find your viewing angle changing, and this looks a little weird. This is because the view is *orthographic*—the way you would see it in an engineering drawing. To get a more realistic view, hit [5] on the numeric keypad. This switches the view to *perspective*—the way we see things in real life.

To pan around the scene, hold down [Shift] and the middle mouse button, and drag. To zoom, you can either use the scroll wheel, or for more precision, hold down [Ctrl] and middle-click, then drag. You can do all this from the numeric pad on the keyboard as well—[2], [4], [6] and [8] to control orbiting (hold down [Ctrl] to pan instead), [7] for a top view, and [1] and [3] for side views. The plus and minus keys zoom in and out respectively, the star key takes you back to the default view, and [Enter] resets



This is what you get when you first start up Blender